

How to Write a Successful Common App Activities List

What's the activities list again? It's the space on the application where you name and briefly describe your non-academic pursuits.

What's its purpose? "Extracurricular activities can be a great opportunity to see how an applicant has self-directed their passions and interests," says Jorge Delgado, Associate Director of International Admissions at Brandeis. "There are only so many hours in the day so seeing how a student has involved themselves outside the academic arena is a great way of understanding their potential fit for a university campus."

Why should you spend 30 minutes up-leveling it?

Your activities list can make a big difference in your application.

Want proof? Compare these two:

Art

Created art and organized club.

Founder, Art Honors Society

Organized and ran meetings, set up field trips, brainstormed and created group art activities, wrote and sent newsletter to members.

Most students write a *pretty good* activities list description and then they stop there. But it doesn't take long to up-level an activities list from *pretty good* to *great*.

Here are three tips for doing that:

Use stronger verbs. I'll define "stronger" in a moment, but in short: Are you describing your activity in the most dynamic way possible? Most students aren't. Why? Because they're using just-okay verbs.

Develop better (and perhaps a bit more) content. Have you included a wide range of responsibilities? Most students forget to include solving problems, gaining skills, and making tangible (and even quantifiable!) impact.

Demonstrate skills & values. Are you communicating what you learned or how an activity changed you? If not, you may be leaving money on the table.

Here's how to make it happen.

THREE TOOLS FOR UP-LEVELING YOUR ACTIVITIES LIST

1. THE EPIC LIST OF ACTIVITIES LIST VERBS.

You probably need stronger verbs. How do I know? I've seen hundreds of Activities Lists and most need stronger verbs.

Compare this typical description of debate:

Member, Debate

Debated topics, attended tournaments, researched topics.

Shall we break that down right quick?

Debated topics (um, redundant)

Attended tournaments (we assumed?)

Researched topics (I hope so!)

Here's a much clearer, more interesting, and more varied description:

I lead research and case writing, mentor younger debate students, organize mock debates, host an annual debate tournament. See Add'l Info for Awards.

FRIENDS, LOOK AT THOSE VERBS:

“lead” (BOOM)

“mentor” (YES)

“organize” (SIZZLE)

“host” (POP)

That's what I'm talking about. I'm like, “Oh, *now* I get what debate looks like to you.” But wait, what makes a verb *stronger*?

A stronger verb ... is more specific.

Example: “taught” is fine, but did you coach, mentor, train, or *demystify*?

A stronger verb ... often provides more information.

Example: “organize” is fine, but did you arrange, catalog, compile, or *systematize*?

A stronger verb ... just sounds better.

A few examples I like: mediate, publicize, administer, or *plagiarize* (I’m kidding about plagiarize, please don’t).

I know, some of you are probably wondering: “But Ethan, which verbs should I use?”

Behold ...

COLLEGE ESSAY GUY'S EPIC LIST OF ACTIVITIES LIST VERBS

Important Note About Overdoing Verbs

As with a resume, you want your activities list to be in your own words, to sound like you. Overwriting can make it sound like you hired a professional to write it, which can detract from your application. So, unless it’s the one and only word that perfectly captures what you did, avoid using “corporate verbs.” See some examples of the words below. I’m not going to say “100% DO NOT use these words.” But at the very least, I am saying “Proceed with caution.”

“Corporate” Verbs I Would Caution Against Using on Your Activities List

allocated	familiarized	projected
apprised	formalized	queried
arbitrated	forecasted	standardized
audited	forged	simulated
augmented	fostered	stimulated
briefed	interceded	substantiated
dispatched	maximized	transmitted
executed	outpaced	validated
expedited	presided	yielded

Heads up: Using this list for ten minutes will up-level your activities list verbs, and thereby your descriptions.

But wait. We’re not done yet. Here’s the second tool for up-leveling your activities list:

2. THE BEABIES EXERCISE

What’s the BEABIES exercise? Simply the **B**est **E**xtracurricular **A**ctivity **B**rainstorm I’ve **E**ver **S**een.

It’s great for developing better content for your activities list.

Instructions: Spend 5-8 minutes filling out a BEABIES chart *per activity on your list* to generate plenty of content for your activities list descriptions. Use the 25 questions below the chart for ideas.

Activity: [Name it here]

WHAT I DID	PROBLEMS I SOLVED	LESSONS LEARNED/SKILLS I GAINED	IMPACT I HAD	HOW I APPLIED WHAT I LEARNED
The key here is active verbs. Tip: Use the “Epic List of Activities List Verbs” I just shared with you	These problems could be: - Personal - Family - Local - Community - School - State-level - National - Global	Tip: Use the Values Exercise for this	This is super important. Tip: Use numbers and actual quotes to support your bullet points	How did you apply lessons from the activity beyond the activity itself? See examples below.

After a few minutes, your chart may look something like this:

Example Activity: Chinese Dance Club

WHAT I DID	PROBLEM S I SOLVED	LESSONS LEARNED/SKIL LS I GAINED	IMPACT I HAD	HOW I APPLIED WHAT I LEARNED
Practiced every Sunday morning for 2.5 hours for 9 years.	Feeling disconnected from Chinese culture and community.	Became more goal-oriented.	Grew closer to the values of Chinese culture, as there is always a story behind every dance.	Used teaching skills while tutoring peers in Chemistry.
Performed at Chinese New Year festivals for 9 years.	Not much connection to relatives in China.	Managed and kept a record of thousands of dollars.		Lessons in leadership helped me manage board members in my club.
Danced in junior group for four years, senior group for five years, senior small group for three years.	Club was struggling to maintain steady funds.	Learned... ..to articulate and explain my thoughts to younger dancers.	Relatives in China watched links to my dances, allowing us to connect more on phone calls.	Continued to reach out to my community about other causes I cared deeply about, helping to fundraise for annual event.
Served as club treasurer, managing club-related funds and handling reimbursements.	Improving technique and artistry in Chinese dancing.	...how to handle conflicting interests from group leaders and dancers' parents.		
	Difficulty transitioning to Chinese dancing from ballet.	...our surrounding community is actually open to supporting our group.	Developed a sense of community within the group of dancers and parents.	
Organized fundraiser at the Chinese Dragon Boat festival that	Difficulty articulating ideas and thoughts.	...to express my individuality in a way that I didn't with ballet.	Showed beauty of Chinese	Helped me become more expressive and seek other

raised over \$2000 for the club. Served as club Vice President. Won Honorable Mention at the Chinese School Association in the United States (CSAUS).	Our community lacked Chinese cultural events.	...every movement and pose has its own nuances. ...how to choreograph and adapt a dance based on material from past dance groups and videos. ...to remain patient and forgiving while teaching.	culture to local community.	outlets of expression .
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25 Questions to Help You Brainstorm More Content for Your Activities List

What I Did (Day-to-Day):

Did I list all my tasks, or just a few? What'd I forget? Go back and check.

Did I list tasks I completed that fell slightly outside the scope of my responsibilities?

Did I leave off any awards? Any uncommon achievements?

Problems I Solved:

Did I consider the internal problems I solved—any personal challenges?

Did I name the external problems I solved—for my friends or family? School? Community?

Was I tackling a much larger (perhaps global) problem?

Lessons I learned & Values/Skills I Developed:

What were some of the soft skills I learned (patience, communication, etc.)?

Did I learn any specific software (Photoshop, Final Cut Pro)?

Languages (Spanish, C++)? Survival skills (how to start a fire or clean a fish)?

What am I better at now than I was before?

What would I have done differently?

Impact I Had (On Self, School, Community and/or Society)

Did I consider the impact this had on my family? Friends? School? Who else benefited?

What impact did this have on me personally? Did this change my life/perspective? How?

Applications to Other Parts of School/Life:

What skills did I develop and lessons did I learn that will make me a better X (tutor, debater, advocate, volunteer, programmer, fill in the blank)? How so?

What did I do to build on and take what I learned to the next level?

What surprised me about this experience?

How might I continue this activity during college and beyond?

FYI: Spend 10-15 minutes filling out a BEABIES chart using these 25 questions and (bonus) you'll have enough content for pretty much any extracurricular activity essay, too.

Here's the third tool for up-leveling your Activities List:

3. THE VALUES SCAN

The Values Scan is a great way to make sure your core values are apparent throughout your application. If you haven't completed the values exercise, [you can do that here](#). It's an awesome (and quick) way to figure out what your top 3-5 core values are.

You're about to use it to make your activities list EXPLODE with depth and variety. How? Like this:

Pick one of the activities list descriptions you've written and ask of it these three questions:

Which values are clearly being revealed in the description?

Which values are kind of being revealed, but could probably be revealed more clearly in the description?

Which values are not in the description at all yet, but perhaps could be included?

Take this description as an example, written by a student who was secretary of her Red Cross Club:

Responsible for taking minutes, updating calendar and active member list, communicating with advisors, acting as a liaison to our local chapter.

Okay, now ask those three questions:

1. Which values is this description clearly revealing?

I see the author is:

Organized: “taking minutes” and “updating calendar”

Responsible and collaborative: “communicating with advisors” and “acting as liaison”

Do you see others? Maybe! But this is a good start. Okay, next ask...

2. Which values could be revealed more clearly in the description?

Reading the example above, I’m curious if the author might demonstrate *leadership* more clearly. She hints at some responsibilities, but I wonder if she could delete “updating calendar and active member list” in favor of a detail more clearly demonstrating leadership skills.

I might ask the student if she can think of something she did that might demonstrate leadership. (If not, that’s okay! This is a process of asking questions and seeing what variety might be possible. But we’re not in the business of making stuff up—see warning note below.) I’d also wonder if the description could more clearly demonstrate the author’s commitment to health—this is the Red Cross, after all—or perhaps social change.

Finally, ask:

3. Which values are not in the description at all yet, but perhaps could be?

To determine the answer for this student, it helps to know the author. I happen to know one of this author's core values was *adaptability*. So I asked her: Did working with the Red Cross help you become more adaptable? If so, how? What detail might show this?

Once you've written a new draft, hand your activities and awards list to a trusted editor. They should have your Values Exercise nearby for reference so they can assess how well you're demonstrating your values. Here's an example:

Indian Tabla

Self-taught via YouTube videos; played drums at community meetings for worker rights awareness; helped my sister become proficient.

I see these values:

Ambition: "Self-taught..."

Social change: "Played drums at community meetings for worker rights awareness"

Family, helping others: "helped sister become more proficient"

See how that works?

Goal: Include 2-3 values per activity. If you can achieve this, just think: your list could demonstrate 20 or 30 values! That's rad. But *don't drive yourself crazy with this*. If your Activities List shows a nice variety of 10 or so values, that's enough. Really.

Once you've got some great verbs and some great content, here are:

10 TIPS FOR MAKING YOUR ACTIVITIES LIST AWESOME

1. Aim for variety, making sure your verbs aren't redundant.

Instead of: *Instructed, helped, taught children tennis* (how are these three different?)

Try: *Instructed in proper technique, while imparting lessons in sportsmanship, health and integrity.*

2. Use the present tense if it's something you still do.

Instead of: *I gave tour campus tours and provided info on school history, student activities, and boarding life.*

Try: *I give campus tours and provide info on school history, student activities, boarding life.*

3. Trim ruthlessly.

Because the space you're using is so limited, the words you choose are incredibly important.

Actually, let me rephrase: Because your space is limited, your word choice is important.

One more time: Limited space demands precise wording.

See what I did there? Cut my character count from 92, to 61, to 37.

In fact...

4. State role, leadership description, and the organization name in the top two sections so you don't waste characters in the 150-character description section.

Activity 1 ↓

Activity type*
Choose an option ▼

Position/Leadership description
(Max characters: 50)*

Organization Name
(Max characters: 100)

Please describe this activity, including what you accomplished and any recognition you received, etc.
(Max characters: 150)*

So instead of:

Position/Leadership description: Editor

Organization Name: School newspaper

Description: I am the editor for the school newspaper

...which wastes space, try instead:

Position/Leadership Description: Editor of International Column

Organization Name: Daily Herald, Ridgewood High School

Description: Responsible for brainstorming and copy-editing articles by underclassmen; managed deadlines; offered layout & design input; liaised w/faculty sponsor."

And are you still using complete sentences? If so, stop. No need here.

So instead of: *I raised money to donate to a school in India by selling t-shirts and bracelets.*

You might end up with: *Arranged advertising events, organized fundraisers, and presented to student body at assemblies (400+ students).*

5. Emphasize tangible, measurable impact.

Notice for example the "400 students" inclusion above. This comes as a result of asking questions like "Whom did your activity help? How many people? How much money did you raise?"

Instead of: *Raised money for children in Africa.*

Try: *Raised \$3,000 to provide three uniforms and scholarships for students attending the Joseph Waweru Home School in Kenya.*

6. Include any responsibilities that demonstrate leadership skills.

Instead of: *I swim on the swim team.*

Try: *Responsible for leading swim practices, planning fundraising events, assisting in recruiting process.*

7. What if there isn't much to say or it was a one-time event?

Instead of: *Tutored students.*

Try: *Provided support to fourth graders with particularly difficult math concepts.* (This works because you've explained the significance of the activity: why the event mattered and to whom).

Or you can...

8. Describe selectivity. This is key if the reader might not understand the achievement your activity represents.

Example: *1 of 2 student leaders elected by my peers to represent our class of 450.*

Another example: *Received 1st place out of 300 competing teams.*

9. Avoid extreme language.

Instead of: *...to help all those in need (or) to end poverty in the world*

Try: *...to help those in need (or) ...to fight against global poverty*

10. If your role was simply “member” or “participant,” it’s okay to just list the activity.

In other words, instead of writing *Participant, MLK Day of Service*

You can just write *MLK Day of Service*

COMMON APP ACTIVITIES LIST EXAMPLES:

Member, (9th,10th) Treasurer (11th, 12th)

National Honors Society, Ridgefield High School Chapter

We are amongst the highest academically achieving students at our school, who collectively and consistently participate in community service projects.

Student, Class TA

Robotics Fundamentals, Online Course at Carnegie Mellon University

Learned the fundamentals of computer programming, robot assembly, and worked as a team in competitions.

Intern

Center for Advanced Head & Neck Surgery, Duluth, MN

Learned how to operate various screening & diagnostic technologies under Dr. Yang; assisted in patient care & diagnosis procedures in Otolaryngology & Oncology.

Leader/Concertmaster

AMAC Youth Chamber Ensemble (AYCE)

Lead ensemble in rehearsal and performance, coordinate rehearsal times, aid younger members in learning music, present free community concerts yearly.

Volunteer (June 2012 - August 2012)

Boys & Girls Club of Santa Monica

Supervised and served as mentor for K-8 grade kids; Helped prepare lunch, entertained, and tutored students in math and science.

Number 3 Starter (August 30th, 2013 - November 11th, 2015)

Varsity Girls Tennis, Robinson Crusoe High School

Practiced and conditioned daily, led daily stretches, competed in district and regional matches against other schools.

Starter

JV/V Beverly Hills High School Tennis Team

Three-year League Champions; planned and hosted team banquet; Coach's Award Recipient. Led practices and motivated teammates to perform at high level.

Local Violin Tutor

Gupta Violin Lesson & Training

Provide aspiring middle school students a foundation on music and basics of violin, demonstrate proper technique, develop strong cognitive and musical skills.

Full-time volunteer EMT (11th - 12th)

Virginia Paramedic Association

Responded to emergency calls, performed BLS protocols, interacted with patients and families, assisted paramedics, organized ambulance rigs. 24 hr/wk for every week.

Volunteer (9th), Summer Intern (10th)

Red Cross of San Fernando Valley

Assisted supervisors, filed paperwork, made phone calls to donors, prepared facilities for training programs by helping with class planning.

“Stretching the Truth” on your Activities List: A Cautionary Tale

I once knew a student who had participated in some wonderful activities. She was a class officer, school club founder, nonprofit volunteer and former intern. With a near-perfect GPA and test scores, she was applying to some of the most highly selective universities in the world. Once her applications had been submitted, however, her counselor revealed to me that the student had falsified parts of her application. She'd listed a trip she hadn't actually taken, for example, made up a leadership role, and padded her hours.

What happened to her? Initially, she was accepted by several highly selective schools. But when one admission officer noticed application details that didn't line up with her counselor's recommendation letter, they brought it to the counselor's attention. After a little research, the counselor found the same inconsistencies and was professionally obligated to inform the highly selective schools that the student's application contained, for lack of a better word, “alternative facts.” (She'd lied.)

When the student was confronted, she claimed she had “stretched the truth” and hadn't technically lied. As far as the counselor and admission officer were concerned in this case, however, “stretching the truth” and “lying” were pretty much the same thing.

As a result, the student's acceptances to those universities were rescinded. In other words: although she was initially accepted, she was ultimately rejected. Worst of all, it damaged her reputation and relationship with her counselors, her principal, and me.

Please don't lie on your Activities List. Don't even stretch the truth. Same goes for your essays too. But you know this.